

Episode 54: Once Upon a Time... (35) – Hospitalisation! Surgery! That Led to My First "Colour Design"! *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* Part 3

Last weekend there was the 17th memorial service for my mother, and I wore a suit for the first time in ages. Oh, formal wear (ceremonial clothes) could be called a suit too (bitter laugh). I wore formal wear in April, but a regular suit (← confusing) was really over a year ago. I was a bit anxious about my body type, but thankfully that was fine (laugh).

Speaking of suits, they always come with neckties. This necktie thing—for people who wear them daily it's nothing, but for "non-suit people" like us, it's surprisingly formidable.

I just can't get the lengths to match properly! (explosion)

The balance between the wide and narrow sides absolutely won't align (crying). Often the narrow side ends up hanging down "limply" from below, and when I redo it, now the wide side aims for my crotch and hangs "limply." And when I try once more, again... it's a standard routine (bitter laugh).

Well, somehow I managed to resolve the situation in three tries, but as always, I get a bit depressed thinking "How is this as a working adult?"

Ah, I really should wear suits sometimes. But in our industry, if you carelessly wear a suit to the studio, people ask with straight faces "Are you quitting the company, Tsujita-san?" which is awkward (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji somehow got off to a start. Episode 1 "Prince! Now Is the Time to Depart" (Direction/Imazawa Tetsuo), Episode 2 "Cruel! Asura King"

(Direction/Umezawa Yoshitoshi), Episode 3 "Reunion! Woman of Geki Female Market" (Direction/Yoshizawa Takao)—with three episodes, the direction and animation staff had made one round. Starting from episode 4, we entered the second rotation round.

By episode 3, each staff member had roughly confirmed the atmosphere and feel of this work. Each director had different "flavours," and those differences mysteriously matched well with each story's taste, allowing all three to work enjoyably.

Toei Doga's Oizumi Studio has a screening room where rushes checks and first print screenings for all works are held. Rushes checks are watched in principle by only the staff responsible for that episode, but other episode staff also come to watch first print screenings of completed works.

Unlike TV series works, without the tight schedule of weekly delivery, staff for the next episode after the one just watched were often still just starting work. So inspired or stimulated by that first print, they'd add a little seasoning to their current work, creating a bit of competition among staff that gradually raised the quality. Eventually, staff from other episodes started coming to rushes checks too.

In *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji*, while direction and animation rotated, art and colour direction kept the same person throughout, so during meetings I could say things like "more △△ feeling than ○○ from the previous episode..." and the directors' requirement levels gradually rose episode by episode, which was incredibly enjoyable (laugh). And the stories themselves progressed to bigger, deeper places.

Entering the rotation from episode 4 in this mood, I fell into a troublesome situation. A physical problem. My left elbow, which I'd been hurting for a while, got considerably worse. I was hit with pain and numbness so bad I could barely hold a pen.

Cubital tunnel syndrome. You know how when you hit your elbow it goes "biiing" with terrible numbness? The cause was inflammation of the nerve passing through exactly

that area. I'd been attending a hospital and enduring with anti-inflammatories and painkillers, but finally reached my limit. So it became surgical treatment. About 2.5 weeks hospitalisation.

Man, I was in trouble (sweat). The story was getting more interesting, with the prince and Taishakuten confronting each other over a woman named Kagami. Moreover, stories continued featuring the raging Taishakuten, the Four Heavenly Kings (Jikokuten, Zouchouten, Koumokuten, Tamonten), and literally dozens of gods called "Thirty-three Heavens." I had to create colour settings for all of them...

However, I couldn't do satisfactory work in this condition, and naturally no one would stop work and wait for someone like me during my hospitalisation, surgery, and recovery period of over a month, even with schedule allowances (laugh).

In the end, I managed to complete colour designs for appearing characters including the "Thirty-three Heavens" before hospitalisation, but had to ask senior colleagues Morita-san and Sakai-san to handle colour direction for episodes 4 and 5 respectively.

Ah, I was supposed to do all episodes myself, but hmm, too bad!

But since it couldn't be helped, I thought things through. "Anyway, I'll decide special colouring and such colour directions, then discuss details thoroughly before asking them to handle it."

Looking back, this became my first case of working with other colour directors as "colour designer."

While I had created character colours for TV series before, the basic approach was for directors and colour directors to meet and proceed with work episode by episode, and I didn't take a stance of actively and deeply involving myself in each episode's content or the colour director's work.

For these two *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* episodes, after meetings with directors and art directors, I arranged separate detailed meetings with the assigned colour directors. I think I also made and provided colour direction schedules.

With surgery decided but waiting for bed availability until the hospitalisation date was confirmed, I frantically rushed through work. But a bed opened earlier than expected, so I was hospitalised much earlier than planned. Some work didn't get finished in time, so I ended up bringing settings to the hospital room and completing unfinished work in the ward's rest room.

This was around the 1990 rainy season (laugh).

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